

# Healing with Horsetail: Exploring plant kinship through ethnographic art practices

Outline, Supplemental Terms, & Transcript for PowerPoint (Flash) Presentation

November 21, 2025 at 10:15 am (American Anthropological Association, AGM)



<https://tinyurl.com/3t7pafkw>

*Note: The .ppt utilizes the Pecha Kucha presentation model, featuring 24 slides, each with a 20-second timer, for a total of 8 minutes in length. A small handout will include artwork, poetry, & horsetail remedies.*

## OUTLINE

- Title
  - Introduction to the problem
  - Inspiration for the research
- Research question and related concepts
  - Plants as kin
  - Contemporary ecological animism
  - Druidry as a spiritual path
  - Visual ways of knowing
- Multispecies Ethnography
  - Cycle 1 & artwork (3 slides)
  - Cycle 2 & artwork (3 slides)
  - Cycle 3 & artwork (4 slides)
- Ecopoetic integration & synthesis (3 slides)
- Findings & conclusion

## SUPPLEMENTAL TERMS & REFERENCES:

This shift of consciousness involved shifting to a relational paradigm in the context of **multispecies ethnography** – a more-than-human approach to ethnographic research that challenges the centrality of humans in conventional ethnography, while also emphasizing the partiality and situatedness of our reality (Campenau, 2024, n.p.); other sources (Kirksey & Helmreich, 2010; van Dooren et al., 2016)

**Ethography** (within the field of Ethnography) provided a mode of responsive encounter that is grounded in *Ethea*, an ethical way of being with others (Rose et al., 2017, p. 122) that emphasizes ethical relations (Van Dooren & Rose, 2016); it provided a way to embody ecological animism.

**Ethographic storytelling** is about becoming witness—or with-ness—which includes paying attention to *ethos*, the details of others' lives, and cultivating the capacity for response-ability (van Dooren & Bird, 2016, p. 89; Haraway, 2016).

**Bricolage or collage** – juxtaposes multiple perspectives (Chilton & Scotti, 2014; Scotti & Chilton, 2019)

**Relational paradigm** - integration of science, nature, and cultural traditions; contextualized as subjective experience; interspecies relations (Viveiros de Castro, 2017; de la Cadena, 2015; de la Cadena & Blaser, 2018)

**Interspecies subjectivity** – accessing liminal realms, the in-between space of relationships (Scotti & Archer, 2016); relational place: intimacy, empathy, and self-reflection (Finlay & Evans, 2009)

**Reflexivity** – recursive integration, researcher positionality & responsibility for situatedness (Berger, 2015)

**Embodied reciprocal relationships** - cultivating “arts of attentiveness” (van Dooren et al., 2016); active listening and noticing when encountering other species; embodiment, bodyfulness, attentive engagement (Caldwell, 2018)

**Embodied writing:** “relating human experience from the inside out,” an enlivened sense of presence in and of the world (Anderson, 2001)

**Kinship, kincentric ecology and kincentric awareness** are terms coined by Indigenous scholars to translate these concepts into the English language (Martinez & Hall, 2008; Salmón, 2000; as cited in LeClair, 2021).

**Animism** – defn: “a particular sensibility and way of relating to various beings in the world. It involves attributing sentience to other beings that may include persons, animals, plants, spirits, the environment, or even items of technology” (Cambridge Encyclopedia of Anthropology, Swancutt, 2019)

**Indigenous Animism** – a way of life, belief: everything is interrelated; Indigenous animisms arise among people who “cultivate a relationship with the land that reflects thousands of years of cohabitation” (Ojalehto, 2020, p. 52)

**Contemporary Ecological Animism** – is simply defined as a “responsive relatedness” (Bird-David, 1999); Val Plumwood (2009) defines **philosophical animism** as a path, a way of life, a mode of encounter, which involves ethical relationships, responsive engagement, thereby expanding concepts of communication, exchange, and agency.

**The Book of Trees** (Lima, 2014) – shows progression of visual symbols associated with trees; symbols became more abstract over time: figurative, vertical, horizontal, multidirectional, radial, rectangular maps, Voronoi maps, circular maps, and sunbursts... follow a linear pattern of growth and production, providing structured patterns to create order and show direct connections

**Rhizomatic thinking** contrasted with tree thinking (Deleuze & Guattari, 1987) – decentralized connections, not based on hierarchy, opening up fixed concepts to “lines of flight” or the tendency toward change; non-linear growth, networked, a way of mapping an emergent experience that requires new ways of seeing that may be hidden... providing a complex system for sharing knowledge in symbiotic relationships.

## TRANSCRIPT (DRAFT):

SLIDE 1: Hello, my name is Sandra Christensen (pronouns: she/they). My doctoral research (CIIS, 2025) was titled “Healing with Horsetail: Exploring plant kinship through ethographic art practices.”

I would like to acknowledge the land where my field research was conducted, specifically the territories of the Dididaht & Nitinaht Nations (Sombrio Beach/ Juan de Fuca Marine Park), a colonized area known as Vancouver Island in the Pacific Northwest (of Canada).

SLIDE 2: I am an adoptee and third-generation settler of mixed European heritage. I am committed to reframing my responsibilities to the land by asking: How can we address harmful human practices due to the instrumental use of plants as resources?

In response to multiple crises of ecological devastation, resource extraction, and consumerism fueled by global economic and corporate dominance, my research focus was on ancient forest communities as places for deep social and ecological healing.

SLIDE 3: While supporting the work of Quw’utsun Elder, Della Rice Sylvester (more than 500 hours in her home, 2017-2018) I deepened my sense of plants as spiritual beings. After horsetail shared a song with me, while gathering medicine for Della, I was able to sustain a plant’s perspective. Deep cultural humility also arose as I sat with discomfort to reconcile my colonial worldview with an Indigenous one.

My inspiration for engaging with embodied art practices came in 2018-2019, while in a home care exchange with artist-activist Marion Cumming [1936-2022]. Set in a peaceful sanctuary, deep reflection through art yielded my first collage based on a forest meditation.

SLIDE 4: As I developed a clearer understanding of an animist and kincentric philosophy, my research inquiry explored the question: **What shift of consciousness happens when we acknowledge plants in general—and horsetail in particular—as kin?**

“Healing with Horsetail” emphasizes a vegetal, kinship perspective that evolved through a transformative and experiential inquiry process that was slow, emergent, recursive, & rhizomatic.

SLIDE 5: Ethographic art practices deepened a connection to the land, allowing for a more complex and sacred expression of plant relationships. They reflected the embodied engagement between horsetail plants and me, as a researcher, which was conceptualized through interspecies subjectivity, reflexivity, and embodied reciprocal relationships.

SLIDE 6: Indigenous eco-centrism (Johnston, 2022) embeds animist and kincentric beliefs within a traditional lifestyle. For a settler like me, this provided a reminder to not just be critical of the dominant colonial system but also to build a sense of responsibility to raise awareness about the value of ancient forest ecosystems, with plants as autonomous, intelligent beings with agency.

*Extra notes: “Indigenous perceptions of self being immersed in the web of life, knowing more-than-humans as **kindred** relations, and understanding how these complex interactions build a sense of human responsibility to preserve and enhance ecosystems” (Salmón, 2000; as cited in LeClair, 2021, p. 232).*

SLIDE 7: As a researcher, I moved from eco-centrism to kin-centrism by engaging in contemporary ecological animism, relating to plants as kin, exploring Druidry as ancestral lineage, and utilizing visual

ways of knowing. I witnessed the intelligence of plants that were aware of kin and participated in social networks, demonstrating adaptability through corrective and innovative responses to the environment.

SLIDE 8: As an adoptee and third-generation settler and colonizer, my identity has been uprooted, fragmented, disjointed, and rhizomatic. While my relationship with horsetail deepened, I acknowledged that I lacked deep-rooted cultural traditions to fully engage in Indigenous animism. Instead, I explored my Indigenous roots in Celtic wisdom and Druidic traditions, which resonated deeply with my animist, nature-centric worldview.

*Extra notes: Emma Restall-Orr (2004, 2012) defines animism as “a monist metaphysical stance, based upon the idea that mind and matter are not distinct and separate substances but an integrated reality, rooted in nature.”*

SLIDE 9: In Druidry, trees are used to represent an alphabet, illustrating how language evolved as a relationship with and expression of the land. Many of the images here show a progression of visual symbols associated with trees, which were used to provide a structure for representing linear patterns of knowledge. In contrast, rhizomatic thinking provided a way of mapping an emergent experience requiring new ways of seeing symbiotic relationships that may be hidden.

*Extra notes: “The Book of Trees” (Lima, 2014) – shows progression of visual symbols associated with trees, with symbols becoming more abstract over time: figurative, vertical, horizontal, multidirectional, radial, rectangular maps, Voronoi maps, circular maps, and sunbursts.*

*Rhizomatic thinking (Deleuze & Guattari, 1987) – decentralized connections, not based on hierarchy, opening up fixed concepts to “lines of flight” or the tendency toward change with more complex, non-linear networked growth.*

SLIDE 10: My research involved three cycles of data gathering between Spring 2022 and Summer 2023 as part of an emergent process. Multispecies ethnography provided a framework to link art practices, narratives, and theory, while allowing time for reflection and integration. My forest (or field) journal included internal dialogue and observations with multiple ways of knowing and perceiving (embodied, sensory, emotional, psychological, intellectual).

SLIDE 11: CYCLE 1 - In the first cycle, I explored several locations in search of horsetail. Sitting with plants was a healing experience, in general, but a trip led to find horsetail in an ancient forest led to a deep healing response to the sudden and tragic loss of a friend and therapist who accidentally drowned. Horsetail connected me with this new, recently departed “ancestor” who communicated with me from another dimension.

Adapting to nature’s rhythms inspired the first major theme: seasons, cyclical stages of growth and development, with death and decay serving as nourishment for the next cycle of growth.

SLIDE 12: As I sat with horsetail plants over several weeks, I began to notice the way specific plants moved and interacted with their environment. Drawing became a way of knowing, and using colored charcoal led to reflections on the connection between fossilized plant remains and the large deposits of coal found in this area. Although many used poisons to kill horsetail, I imagined all the ways humans have been transforming fossilized remains—the bones of plantcestors—into oil, gas, and plastic.

SLIDE 13: In Cycle 1, I began by creating digital collages from my photographs, providing succinct impressions of each site, with a map and close-up images to emphasize the abundance of horsetail.

The waterfall collage was particularly meaningful, as I wanted to transmit the profound healing experience conducted by horsetail through the element of water. Images in multiple scales illustrate how horsetail and skunk cabbage became “larger than life” when dominating my conscious awareness. It was later that evening, still pulsing with the spirit of horsetail, that I connected with my friend who had passed over to another dimension.

*Extra notes/excerpts from my journal:*

*“I followed the sound of rushing water. As the sounds flooded my being, I inhaled humid air, saturated with water, fine droplets dissolving on my tongue and moistening my skin. Further in, there was another opening above, where water rushed in and down the rocky cliff, water pooling at the bottom. I allowed the sounds to fill my being and wash over and through me, dissolving my sense of self to merge with the presence of water—cleansing, reviving, restoring, enlivening... Standing in the cave, leaning against the rock wall, looking up at the waterfall, feeling the spray, drowning myself in the sounds that surround me, rushing through me, dissolving my emotions into a slurry, all one deep shudder of life.” (S. Christensen, Forest Journal, 16 April 2022)*

*“Driving home, horsetail (and swamp lantern/skunk cabbage) began to magically appear in all the landscapes, jumping out and glowing with an inner light. [Perhaps due to] having consumed the juice from fresh green stalks, I felt a connection with this glowing light for the rest of the day and through the night.” (Sandra Christensen, Forest Journal, 16 April 2022)*

SLIDE 14: CYCLE 2: After incorporating seasonal rhythms into my research process, the thematic focus in Cycle 2 was on the deep shifts to my concept of time, enriched by Joanna Macy’s concept of deep time and Michael Marder’s treatise on “plant time.” This collage illustrates deep time in the evolutionary relationship between humans and horsetail, with humans appearing in a thin top layer.

SLIDE 15: In my art practice, I explored Gemma Anderson’s dynamic drawing method inspired by von Goethe’s. In one experiment, I explored imaginal realms by splattering ink on a page and allowing a subject and image to emerge. This led to a deeper exploration of organic forms contained in a booklet.

*Extra notes: Gemma Anderson, in “Drawing as a Way of Knowing in Art and Science” (2019), applied Goethe’s drawing method to represent the dynamic nature of living systems, and added a new method she called “isomorphology” as a way of exploring random occurrences and mutations, acknowledging and valuing the uncertainty that characterizes the creative process (p. 193, 208).*

*The image of spores was partly inspired by the film “The Walking and Jumping Spores of Horsetail Plants” (2013) by scientist Philippe Marmottant. Spore movement is created by increasing and decreasing levels of humidity, which causes their “elators” to expand and contract, thus allowing them to effectively disperse by leaping across the ground and through the air—a locomotion mechanism not observed in other spore plants.*

Source: YouTube. <https://youtu.be/RvC4pOb7MhE?si=1jqM1W7y0nOzRp1e>.

SLIDE 16: In Cycle 2, I made many sound recordings next to horsetail plants. This artwork was inspired by sitting in the forest and imagining what horsetail could hear. Listening *with* horsetail was about tuning

into other life forms, including mosses, ferns, lichens, trees, insects, birds, and animals. During the creative process, deer popped into my awareness as an animal guide, providing another reminder for “listening with.”

**SLIDE 17: CYCLE 3:** In Cycle 3, I spent two weeks at Sombrio gathering data. I also performed a Druid self-guided initiation ritual, which inspired the next theme represented by the Druid symbol of “AWEN.” I felt a strong, energetic force at the waterfall site; here, the three strands of energy represent this meeting place of land, sea, and sky.

*Extra notes: Calas (Land) - form, Gwyar (Sea) - movement, Nwfyre (Sky) – air/ vibration (sound)*

**SLIDE 18:** Hampered by torrential rains, initial sketches of horsetail plants done inside the camper van contrasted with plants sketched live at the Ditch site, embedded in the forest. At the waterfall site, where I enacted my Druid initiation ceremony, the feeling of AWEN was very powerful, as the land, sea, and sky continually morphed and changed color.

*Extra notes: I observed not only how the horsetail plant resembled animals, but also how ki mirrored the forest and surrounding landscape. In a similar way, the driftwood embedded in the stream seemed to be alive, sometimes resembling the shapes of animals. From this observation, I sensed how local Indigenous carvers might reveal the spirit forms that are already present in wood and stone, and I became aware of shapes appearing on the paper before I drew them.*

**SLIDE 19:** During art classes, I began with splatters of blue ink to explore horsetail’s connection with water. “Pacific Eel Bed” retains a sense of fluidity and motion, while “Waterways with Horsetail” emphasizes how ki regulates flow in underground rhizomatic networks. In “Plantcestral Memories,” images emerged while listening to soundscapes and imagining how the first vascular plants moved from water to land.

*Extra notes: Layla Kristy Feghali, of River Rose Re-membrance and Apothecary and the SWANA Ancestral Medicine HUB popularized the term “plantcestors”: “[These ancient living organisms] are our ancestors’ ancestors, amongst the earliest and most ancient beings whose livelihood, sacrifices, and brilliance have made human and animal life possible upon this Earth” (2015).*

**SLIDE 20:** My art style was significantly transformed by listening to soundscapes as part of the creative process. In “Listening with Horsetail,” the recordings were taken in the forest, high above the beach; the vibrations of sound can be felt viscerally in this artwork. In the process, I experienced synesthesia, in which sounds were perceived as colors.

**SLIDE 21:** Two community-based workshops provided a fertile space for synthesizing what I gleaned from horsetail. As shown, “Mapping my writing ecosystems” (CWS & Women’s Spirituality, “Writing in relationship(s): Mapping our writing ecosystems” with Amanda & Amie on April 5<sup>th</sup> & 19<sup>th</sup>, 2024) was accompanied by a narrative to explore the connections between my embodied writing process, the life cycle of horsetail, and the seasonal rhythms of the land.

**SLIDE 22:** Next are two poems created during the series: “Re-Storying our Relations with the Natural World” (Sierra Club in Fall 2023, with facilitator Andrea Vela Alarcón), both found in my handout. The first poem “to horsetail” extends Robin Kimmerer’s (2013) concepts about the grammar of animacy by changing a noun to a verb: What is a horsetail way of being in the world?

### **to horsetail (HANDOUT)**

living fossils open up deep time,  
past-present-future in one  
*Upsprung*: bi-sexual plants,  
popping up, up in the spring  
jumping spores using humidity  
transporting ki to new zones  
expanding rhizomatic networks  
colonizing underground realms  
photosynthesizing thru spiky leaves  
like a plasma ball:  
electric signaling thru touch sensing silica  
transmitting & receiving signals  
more sophisticated than manufactured silicon,  
transporting water thru tubular stems and rhizomes  
pulling through minerals and nutrients  
regulating steady flow of water thru earth bodies

SLIDE 23: In a subsequent workshop, we were invited to create propositions inspired by Yoko Ono's "Touch Poems" as a tribute to the art of Nam June Paik (1960s), who stated that "it has to do with communication on a different dimension." You are invited to take a moment to consider my horsetail proposition.

### **MY PROPOSITION: (HANDOUT)**

- imagine a time before humans, animals and birds, a time before dinosaurs when plants moved from water onto the land
- listen to sounds of water: raindrops, splashes, waves, streams, waterfalls, cenotes
- listen without your ears, opening your heart as wide as this world

SLIDE 24: Plants are interdependent ecological beings. Embedded within the widest understanding of multiple interconnected selves, ethnographic art practices offer a way of integrating embodied encounters with plant kin by opening the senses, actively listening, and navigating an ecological self, which can support the healing needed for radical transformation (Jeanine Canty, 2014).

### **What did I learn from horsetail? (HANDOUT)**

- A song that opened my heart
- To sit and listen deeply
- Greening power of plants = vital energy
- Plant time creates spaces for deep healing, opens a portal to other dimensions
- My ancestral lineage began with plantcestors (horsetail = 320 mya)
- Ingesting & conspiring with horsetail = reciprocal exchange
- As an interdependent ecological being, plants are my kin
- As my teachers, I am devoted to their care and our mutual well-being.